

Livio Silva-Muller

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

2025-2027 **Harvard University, United States**
Academy Scholar, Harvard Academy for International & Area Studies

EDUCATION

2019-2025 **The Geneva Graduate Institute, Switzerland**
Ph.D. in Sociology
2023-2025 **London School of Economics, United Kingdom**
Visiting Ph.D. Researcher, Department of Methodology
2017-2019 **The Geneva Graduate Institute, Switzerland**
M.Phil. in Development Studies
2013-2016 **University of St. Gallen, Switzerland**
B.A. in International Relations

PUBLICATIONS

Silva-Muller, L. (2026), "Reach and Retrenchment of the Environmental State: Global Climate Politics in the Amazon Rainforest". *American Journal of Sociology*. doi:[10.1086/741696](https://doi.org/10.1086/741696)

* Winner of the Political Sociology Student Paper Award, American Sociological Association

* Winner of the Development Sociology Student Paper Award, American Sociological Association

* Winner of the Environmental Sociology Student Paper Award, American Sociological Association

Silva-Muller, L. & Sposito, H. (2024). Which Amazon Problem? Problem-Constructions and Transnationalism in Brazilian Presidential Discourse since 1985. *Environmental Politics* 33(3):398–421. doi: [10.1080/09644016.2023.2220639](https://doi.org/10.1080/09644016.2023.2220639).

* Winner of the Amazonian Section Best Paper Award, Latin America Studies Association

Silva-Muller, L., Moraes Silva, G., & López, M. (Forthcoming, 2026). Whose merit, which redistribution? Elites, taxes, and transfers in Brazil and South Africa. *Social Forces*.

Teeger, C., **L. Silva-Muller**, and G. Moraes Silva. (2025). "How Race Matters for Elites' Views on Redistribution." *The British Journal of Sociology*. doi:[10.1111/1468-4446.70012](https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-4446.70012).

Silva-Muller, L., (2022). Payment for ecosystem services and the practices of environmental fieldworkers in policy implementation: The case of Bolsa Floresta in the Brazilian Amazon. *Land Use Policy*, 120. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.landusepol.2022.106251>

Silva-Muller, L., & Faul, M. (2022). Protecting the Amazon and its people: the role of civil society in the local effectiveness of transnational partnerships. In *Partnerships for Sustainability: Pathways to Effectiveness*. Edt. by Andonova, L., Faul, M. and Piselli, D. Routledge: London. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003148371-6>

WORK IN PROGRESS

- Silva-Muller, L.** “Qualitative Methods and the Digital Era: How computation entangles fieldwork?” [*Under Review*]
- Moraes Silva, Graziella; Lopéz, Matias; **Silva-Muller, L.** & Thome, Debora “Putting power into boxes: Challenges and advantages of conducting surveys with elites” [*Under Review*]
- Silva-Muller, L.** " An Autopsy of State Finance under Bolsonaro: How Jurisdictional Hedging Insulate Policies from State Dismantlers" [*Full Draft*]
- Reis, Elisa; Moraes Silva, Graziella; and **Silva-Muller, L.** “From ‘Third Wave to the Backlash: changes and continuities in Brazilian elite’s perceptions of democracy” [*Full Draft*]
- Silva-Muller, L.** & Sposito, H. “Do Backsliders defund the liberal world? The United States, Brazil, and Constrained Re-engagement in the United Nations” [*Full draft*]
- Silva-Muller, L.** “Easy and Hard Decarbonization: The (Im)possibility of Ecological Modernization in Latin America” [*Writing Up*]

BOOK PROJECT

- Silva-Muller, L.** “Bureaucratic Contradictions and the Green Transition: Environmental versus Developmental State in the Amazon Rainforest.”

COMMISSIONED STUDIES

- Silva-Muller, L.**; Gassmann, R.; & De Franco, Guilherme (2025) “Paying for Multilateralism Amid Global Shocks: International Geneva, 2016 to 2023”, study commissioned by the Republic and State of Geneva: [Available here](#).
- Silva-Muller, L.** & Gassmann, R. (2024) “Paying for Multilateralism: Taking Stock on the Financing of International Organisations in Geneva, 2000-2020”, study commissioned by the Republic and State of Geneva: [Available here](#).

HONOURS AND PRIZES

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| 2025 | Environmental Sociology Graduate Student Paper Award, American Sociological Association |
| 2024 | Political Sociology Graduate Student Paper Award, American Sociological Association |
| 2024 | Sociology of Development Outstanding Graduate Student Paper Award, American Sociological Association |
| 2024 | Best Paper in Amazonian Studies, Latin American Studies Association |

COMPETITIVE EXTERNAL GRANTS

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| 2023 | SNF Project Doctoral Mobility Grant |
| 2023 | The Swiss Secretariat for Education Early-Career Grant |
| 2022 | SNIS Project Funding-Democracy and Redistribution in the Global South |
| 2021 | SNIS International Organization Research Grant |
| 2018 | The Davis Peace Project Grant by Davis UWC Scholars |
| 2015 | The Japanese Government JASSO scholarship |

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- Fundamentals of R (convener, postgraduate level, from 2021 to 2024)
- Research Methods in Anthropology and Sociology (postgraduate level, from 2021 to 2024)
- Elites and Inequality (postgraduate level, from 2021 to 2024)

INVITED TALKS

- 2026 “How Brazil decarbonized the Amazon Rainforest?” David Rockefeller Center for Latin American Studies, Harvard University
- 2026 “Insulating Decarbonization from Bolsonaro: How Transnational Finance Shields Policy in Times of Democratic Backsliding”, Watson School of International and Public Affairs, Brown University
- 2025 “Paying for Multilateralism Amid Global Shocks”, lecture for diplomats and International Organization Staff in Geneva.
- 2024 “Paying for Multilateralism” Panel with policy makers in Geneva, [available here](#).
- 2023 “Transnational Climate Regimes in Rainforest States: The Case of Brazil from 1985 to 2022”, FGV IR Department Research Seminar, São Paulo-BR
- 2022 “Expanding Payment for Ecosystem Services in the Brazilian Amazon,” invited talk at FEA-USP's 3rd Bioeconomy Workshop, São Paulo, [available here](#).
- 2019 "Payment for ecosystem Services in the Brazilian Amazon", invited talk at Oak Foundation, Genève.

SELECTED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

*ASA = American Sociological Association

“Do Backsliders defund the UN?”

- 2026 European Political Sciences Society
- 2026 Latin American Studies Association
- 2026 Authoritarian Political System Group Seminar
- 2026 Sociology of Development Conference

"Qualitative Methods in the Digital Era"

- 2026 ASA, Methods Section
- 2026 From Live Diplomacy to Living Archives Workshop (IHEID, Geneva)
- 2025 LSE Computational Social Sciences Meets Qualitative Research Workshop

"Insulating Decarbonization: How Jurisdictional Hedging Safeguards Policy from State Dismantlers?"

- 2026 Junior Theorist Symposium (ASA pre-conference)
- 2025 ASA, Global and Transnational Sociology Section Session
- 2025 Red para el Estudio de la Economía Política de América Latina
- 2024 Society for the Advancement of Socioeconomics
- 2024 Red para el Estudio de la Economía Política de América Latina

"Reach and Retrenchment of the Environmental State"

- 2024 Conference of the British Journal of Sociology
- 2024 ASA, Environmental Sociology Section Session
- 2024 Ph.D. Seminar, Doing International Political Sociology, London
- 2023 Red para el Estudio de la Economía Política de América Latina
- 2023 Society for the Advancement of Socioeconomics
- 2022 ASA, Global and Transnational Sociology Section Session

"Whose Merit, Which Redistribution?" with G. Moraes Silva

- 2026 ASA, Culture and Inequality Section
- 2024 Society for the Advancement of Socioeconomics
- 2023 ASA; Inequality, Poverty, and Mobility Section Session

"How Race Matters for Elites' Views of Redistribution" with Chana Teegeer and Graziella Moraes Silva

- 2024 Conference of the British Journal of Sociology
- 2024 Society for the Advancement of Socioeconomics
- 2024 ASA, Culture and Inequality Section Session

"Fear and Trust in Unequal Democracies: Elites and the Politics of Redistribution in the Global South" with G. Moraes Silva, M. Lopez & C. Teegeer,

- ASA, 2023 Sociology of Development Section Session
- 2024 Society for the Advancement of Socioeconomics

"The problem of climate change and comparative historical sociology"

- 2024 Doing Sociology Now, Department of Sociology, London School of Economics

LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

Languages Portuguese (native), English (proficient), German (proficient), Spanish (intermediary), French (intermediary).

Data Science Advanced user of **R** programming language (github; baseR; network analysis; text-as-data; web scrapping; survey analysis; tidyverse; markdown)

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Organization

Sociology of Development Conference, 2026, Princeton University

Elites in Unequal Democracies, 2025, Geneva Graduate Institute

Reviewer

American Journal of Sociology; Environmental Politics, Revista de Estudios Brasileños; Swiss Secretariat for Education, Research, and Innovation.

Awards Committee

Committee Member: ASA Political Sociology Best Graduate Student Paper Award (2025), ASA Development Sociology Best Graduate Student Paper Award (2025).

Administrative Service

Member of the Geneva Graduate Institute Sustainability Target Initiative (2021-2025);

Member of the Geneva Graduate Institute Governance Group (2020-21);

Anthropology and Sociology PhD Student Representative (2021-2023).

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT AND MEDIA REFERENCES

Citations in Government and Institutional Documents

[Kanton of Geneva Law Proposal on Rescuing IOs from Defunding](#), 2025

[Official Brazilian Government Evaluation of Amazon Fund](#), 2023

Podcast and Panels

[UN Library Podcast on Paying for Multilateralism](#), September 2024

[Paying for Multilateralism panel with ICRC vice-president](#), June 2024

Media Coverage

[“Como a Amazônia é vista em discursos presidenciais brasileiros, desde 1985”](#), October 2025,

Nexo Newspaper, Brazil

[“Is Geneva prepared for Trump’s—and others’— cuts from foreign aid?”](#), March 2025, Swissinfo

[“Trump and Multilateralism: The un-making of the UN started”](#), February 2025, Swiss Radio and Television.

MEMBERSHIPS

American Sociological Association (ASA)

Society for Advancement of Socioeconomics (SASE)

Latin American Studies Association (LASA)

Swiss School of Latin American Studies (SSLAS)

Latin America Political Economy Network (REPAL)